

Primary Source Reading: Plato's *Euthyphro* (4b–12e)

Philosophy Honors: Ethics / Lesson 1.01 — The Question We Cannot Avoid Translated by Benjamin Jowett

Before you read: Socrates has been indicted for impiety and is waiting outside the court of the King Archon when he meets Euthyphro, who is there to prosecute his own father for murder — something no one did in ancient Athens. Euthyphro is completely confident this is the pious thing to do. Socrates wants to know what piety actually is before deciding whether to be impressed. As you read, track each definition Euthyphro offers and the specific reason Socrates finds it insufficient. You will need at least two of these, with your own notes, for the discussion assignment.

The Case Against His Father

SOCRATES: And of what is he accused?

EUTHYPHRO: Of murder, Socrates.

SOCRATES: By the powers, Euthyphro! How little does the common herd know of the nature of right and truth. A man must be an extraordinary man, and have made great strides in wisdom, before he could have seen his way to bring such an action.

EUTHYPHRO: ...Now the man who is dead was a poor dependent of mine who worked for us as a field labourer on our farm in Naxos, and one day in a fit of drunken passion he got into a quarrel with one of our domestic servants and slew him. My father bound him hand and foot and threw him into a ditch, and then sent to Athens to ask of a diviner what he should do with him. Meanwhile he never attended to him and took no care about him, for he regarded him as a murderer... For such was the effect of cold and hunger and chains upon him, that before the messenger returned from the diviner, he was dead. And my father and family are angry with me for taking the part of the murderer and prosecuting my father. They say that... a son is impious who prosecutes a father. Which shows, Socrates, how little they know what the gods think about piety and impiety. (4b–e)

First Definition: Piety Is What I Am Doing

SOCRATES: I adjure you to tell me the nature of piety and impiety... Tell me what is the nature of this idea, and then I shall have a standard to which I may look, and by which I may measure actions, whether yours or those of any one else, and then I shall be able to say that such and such an action is pious, such another impious. (6d–e)

EUTHYPHRO: Piety is doing as I am doing; that is to say, prosecuting any one who is guilty of murder, sacrilege, or of any similar crime — whether he be your father or mother, or whoever he may be — that makes no difference; and not to prosecute them is impiety. (5d)

SOCRATES: Remember that I did not ask you to give me two or three examples of piety, but to explain the general idea which makes all pious things to be pious.

Second Definition: Piety Is What the Gods Love

EUTHYPHRO: Piety, then, is that which is dear to the gods, and impiety is that which is not dear to them. (6e–7a)

SOCRATES: But the gods were admitted to have enmities and hatreds and differences? ... And the quarrels of the gods, noble Euthyphro, when they occur, are of a like nature? They have differences of opinion about good and evil, just and unjust, honourable and dishonourable — there would have been no quarrels among them, if there had been no such differences, would there?

EUTHYPHRO: You are quite right.

SOCRATES: Then the same things are hated by the gods and loved by the gods, and are both hateful and dear to them?

EUTHYPHRO: True.

SOCRATES: And upon this view the same things, Euthyphro, will be pious and also impious?

EUTHYPHRO: So I should suppose.

SOCRATES: Then, my friend, I remark with surprise that you have not answered the question which I asked. For I certainly did not ask you to tell me what action is both pious and impious. (7e–8a)

Third Definition: What All the Gods Love — and the Dilemma

SOCRATES: I will amend the definition so far as to say that what all the gods hate is impious, and what they love pious or holy; and what some of them love and others hate is both or neither. Shall this be our definition of piety and impiety?

EUTHYPHRO: Why not, Socrates?

SOCRATES: The point which I should first wish to understand is whether the pious or holy is beloved by the gods because it is holy, or holy because it is beloved of the gods. (9e–10a)

...Thus you appear to me, Euthyphro, when I ask you what is the essence of holiness, to offer an attribute only, and not the essence — the attribute of being loved by all the gods. But you still refuse to explain to me the nature of holiness. (10e–11a)

Fourth Definition: Piety as a Part of Justice

[Euthyphro grows frustrated — his arguments keep “walking away,” as Socrates jokes, like the moving statues of his mythical ancestor Daedalus. Socrates offers to help him toward a new attempt.]

SOCRATES: Is not that which is pious necessarily just?

EUTHYPHRO: Yes.

SOCRATES: And is, then, all which is just pious? or, is that which is pious all just, but that which is just, only in part and not all, pious?

EUTHYPHRO: I do not understand you, Socrates.

SOCRATES: ...Justice is the more extended notion of which piety is only a part. Do you dissent?

EUTHYPHRO: No, I think that you are quite right.

SOCRATES: Then, if piety is a part of justice, I suppose that we should enquire what part? ... In like manner, I want you to tell me what part of justice is piety or holiness.

EUTHYPHRO: Piety or holiness, Socrates, appears to me to be that part of justice which attends to the gods, as there is the other part of justice which attends to men. (11e–12e)

SOCRATES: That is good, Euthyphro; yet still there is a little point about which I should like to have further information. What is the meaning of “attention”? For attention can hardly be used in the same sense when applied to the gods as when applied to other things. For instance, horses are said to require attention, and not every person is able to attend to them, but only a person skilled in horsemanship... In like manner holiness or piety is the art of attending to the gods? — that would be your meaning, Euthyphro?

EUTHYPHRO: Yes.

After you read: By this point Euthyphro has offered several answers, and each has failed for a different, specific reason. Notice that Socrates never claims Euthyphro’s confidence is misplaced — he never says Euthyphro is wrong to prosecute his father. What he presses on is something narrower: whether Euthyphro can say what makes an action pious, in a way that would let him — or anyone — judge new cases correctly. For your discussion post, choose at least two of Euthyphro’s definitions, and for each one write down: what the definition claims, and the specific move Socrates makes to show it doesn’t hold up.